

Leadgrid Akademi: Mapping Norway's Sales & Lead-Gen Experts + An Outreach and Credibility Strategy

TL;DR

- **Norway has a small but identifiable cluster of credible sales/lead-gen authorities you can anchor an academy around** — the strongest "flagship" candidate is Christian Hofbauer, author of *Salgets helter*, the B2B-sales book used as curriculum at BI, Høyskolen Kristiania and Høyskolen Innlandet; supporting voices include podcasters Ståle Lindblad (*Salgsrommet*) and Hans Haugan (*B2B salg i endring*), the Inbound agency team behind *Inboundpodden* and "Norway's largest B2B survey," keynote speaker Morten Brandt, and LinkedIn/lead-gen specialist Hallgeir Gustavsen.
- **Win credibility the Norwegian way: lead with genuine value and peer respect, not cash or hype.** In a small, egalitarian, trust-based market, a curriculum-author or academic anchor plus association with communities like MFO (Markedsføringsforeningen i Oslo, 5,000+ members) and SRF Bergen buys more trust than paid endorsements.
- **Sequence the rollout in three phases:** (1) sign 1–2 respected anchors (a curriculum author + a podcaster) as an editorial advisory board; (2) run low-friction interview/podcast content that repurposes experts' existing material; (3) scale into co-created masterclasses and an ambassador tier — always keeping the academy educational, not promotional.

Key Findings

1. The credible Norwegian sales/lead-gen landscape is real but concentrated. There is no Norwegian equivalent of a mega-influencer sales guru, but there is a well-defined tier of authors, podcasters, trainers, agency leaders and communities. The single most institution-backed figure is Christian Hofbauer, whose book is on university syllabi — an unusually strong, verifiable credibility signal.

2. Podcasts are the center of gravity. Norwegian-language sales/B2B podcasts (*Salgsrommet*, *B2B salg i endring*, *Inboundpodden*) are the most active, warm-audience channels and the easiest, lowest-friction way to co-create content with experts.

3. Communities and events matter more than individual "influencers." MFO (Oslo, 5,000+ members), SRF Bergen (Salgskonferansen), and Markedsføringsforeningen i Stavanger are the network hubs. Association with these institutions transfers trust efficiently in Norway's relationship-driven culture.

4. The right strategy is value-first, peer-to-peer, low-commercial. US-style "affiliate/ambassador with revenue share" works poorly as an opening move in Norway. Advisory-board framing, co-branding with respected names, and genuine audience/exposure offers fit the culture better. The business case is real: per the 2024 Edelman-LinkedIn B2B Thought Leadership Impact Report (a survey of ~3,500 professionals across seven countries),

45% of decision-makers and 48% of C-suite executives said a company's thought leadership directly led them to award it business.

Details

PART 1 — The Norwegian Sales & Lead-Generation Expert Landscape

A. Sales authors & thought-leaders (highest credibility for an academy)

- **Christian Hofbauer** — *The flagship candidate*. Author of *Salgets helter - en bok om B2B salg* (Universitetsforlaget, 2016, ISBN 9788215024448), which is pensum (curriculum) at essentially all Norwegian universities/colleges teaching salgsledelse, including BI, Høyskolen Kristiania and Høyskolen Innlandet. Master from BI + MSc from Stirling; partner/advisor at recruitment firm Orion & Partners; has helped design sales academies for national and international companies; keynote speaker on salg and salgsledelse. He is uniquely positioned because his authority is institutionally validated, not self-declared. Ideal anchor/editorial lead. [Orion](#) [Hofbauer](#)
- **Atle Øi** — Author of *Jeg er en selger* (Hegnar Bok), a practical, accessible sales book; career from door-to-door selling to sales management in media; coaching-certified (2015). Good fit for motivational/foundational content.
- **Petter A. Berg** — Author of *Kunsten å selge* (Cappelen Damm, now 5th edition), a long-standing Norwegian sales textbook, and *Salgsledelse*. Academic/textbook credibility.
- **Gorm Kunøe** — Longtime BI faculty (førstelektor) in sales/salgsledelse and CRM; author of *Salg og salgsledelse med CRM-systemer*; academic authority for a "learn the theory from a professor" module.
- **Amund Fjeldstad** (*Vinn salget: om salgsprosess og closing*, 2017) and **Eirik Petersen** (*Nå dine salgsmål*, 2009) are additional Norwegian-language sales authors, though their titles are older.

B. Sales podcasters & content creators (best low-friction collaborators)

- **Ståle Lindblad** — Host of *Salgsrommet* ("the salespeople's own podcast," hosted on Acast), 25+ years in sales; gründer, writer and speaker focused on digitalization, communication and social media. Each episode features guests sharing sales knowledge — a natural co-creation partner and a channel that already reaches your target audience. [LinkedIn](#) [Podtoppen](#)
- **Hans Haugan** — Host of *B2B salg i endring* and behind Effekt Digital, which helps growth-oriented B2B companies with sales and digital marketing; 25 years in B2B sales. Squarely on-topic for lead generation and modern B2B selling.
- **Inbound (agency)** — **Tor Magnus Kolflaath & Camilla Tryggestad Visjø** — Host *Inboundpodden* (B2B marketing/growth for leaders) and produce *B2B-rapporten*, billed as "Norges største undersøkelse om B2B-salg og -markedsføring," based on 650 Norwegian B2B companies and produced every two years with MFO and Norstat. A headline 2025 finding: "58 prosent av virksomheter hvor salg og marked samarbeider godt, oppnår ønskede resultater. Bare 28 prosent lykkes når samarbeidet er dårlig."

Inbound bills itself as "Norway's first inbound marketing agency." Strong data-backed credibility for the lead-gen/demand-gen side of the academy.

C. Sales trainers & coaches

- **Morten Brandt** — Arguably Norway's best-known sales keynote speaker (career at Euro Business School since 1988; now own company). Signature keynote "Supersalg – Kunsten å påvirke"; author of sales-inspiration material. (Note: his "4,000+ talks / ~300,000 participants" figures are self-reported.) High name recognition for a flagship live event.
- **Jens Hartvik (Salgstinget AS)** — Founded Salgstinget in 1995; gestalt therapist + certified coach; markets himself as one of Norway's toughest sales/leadership trainers; corporate references include Bertel O. Steen and Gyldendal.
- **Kenneth Opsahl (Salgscoach.no / Opsahl Consulting)** — Oslo-based sales coach, 20-25+ years' experience, certified mental trainer; part of the "Marshmallow" consultant network that won the 2024 Konsulentprisen for work with Würth Norge.
- **Øystein Vangsnes** — One of Norway's sought-after speakers on salg, kundeservice and culture-building; bookable via speaker agencies (Athenas, Foredragsholder.no).
- **Dale Carnegie Norge** — In Norway since 1983; ISO-certified sales-training programs; institutional brand for a "training methodology" module.

D. Lead generation / demand generation / digital-marketing experts & agencies

- **Hallgeir Gustavsen (Make More)** — B2B LinkedIn/lead-gen specialist; markets himself as "Norway's only LinkedIn Certified Marketing Expert"; content-heavy blog on LinkedIn strategy, demand generation, RevOps and HubSpot; CRO with ~25 years bridging sales and marketing. Directly on-topic for lead generation. (Self-marketing claims; follower count unverified.)
- **Inbound** (see above) — the leading inbound/lead-gen agency voice with proprietary research.
- Other agencies active in Norwegian B2B lead gen/ABM/LinkedIn: Make More, Adcomer, Mementor, Nuet Marketing.

E. High-reach LinkedIn / digital voices (adjacent, for reach)

- **Alexander Haneng** — ~14,000 LinkedIn followers (self-reported 31% growth in 12 months); works at Digital Norway (AI adoption); ex-Posten/Bring digital-innovation director; runs the *Ledertips* leadership podcast and co-founded the DigitalBar Oslo meetup. More digital/e-commerce/AI than pure sales, but a genuine reach amplifier and credible name.

F. Communities, associations & events (network hubs)

- **MFO - Markedsføringsforeningen i Oslo** — Per mfo.no's "Om oss": "Foreningen har i dag over 5000 medlemmer... Markedsføringsforeningen i Oslo er over 100 år gammel." (Founded as Reklameforeningen i Kristiania in 1915; adopted the current name in 1969.)

Monthly frokostmøter; publishes B2B research with Inbound; the single most valuable community to associate with in Oslo.

- **SRF - Salgs- og Reklameforeningen i Bergen** — ~50 events/year; runs Salgskonferansen and a sales network; hub for the Bergen region; hosts the *Market Mad* podcast.
- **Markedsføringsforeningen i Stavanger (MFFS)** — active since 1936; regional hub.
- **Events:** Salgskonferansen (SRF Bergen); Rock Sales 2026 (WE ROCK SALES, with Finansavisen, crowns "Norges Beste Selgere"); HSMAI "Future of Sales" (Oslo); Salgs- og Markedskonferansen (Nordic Management Institute + Color Line). *Salg24*, the former dedicated online newspaper for salespeople, closed after ~2 years for lack of commercial basis — a cautionary datapoint about monetizing sales-media in Norway.

PART 2 — Outreach & Credibility Strategy

1. Guiding principle: value-first, peer-to-peer, low-commercial

In a small, egalitarian, trust-based Norwegian market, credibility is transferred through genuine peer respect and institutional association, not through paid hype or flashy US-style endorsements. The demand-gen payoff is documented: per the 2024 Edelman-LinkedIn report, 45% of decision-makers (48% of C-suite) awarded business because of a company's thought leadership. The academy is therefore a legitimate demand-gen asset — provided it is genuinely educational.

2. Collaboration models (ranked by friction, low to high)

- **Interview / podcast guest content (lowest friction):** interview experts or appear on their podcasts (*Salgsrommet*, *B2B salg i endring*, *Inboundpodden*). Repurpose into academy articles, clips, transcripts. Attractive because it uses material they already know cold.
- **Guest article / "tips" contributions:** a short written or recorded tip, ghost-supported by your team so the expert only reviews and approves.
- **Editorial / advisory board:** name 3–5 respected experts as an advisory board that lends its name and light guidance. High credibility, moderate commitment.
- **Webinars / masterclasses:** live or recorded sessions co-branded with the expert.
- **Co-created courses:** deeper, revenue-relevant collaboration — reserve for proven partners.
- **Ambassador / affiliate / revenue-share:** the most commercial — introduce LAST and only with warm partners, or it will read as "selling out" in the Norwegian context.
- **Speaking at a Leadgrid event:** a flagship live event (or a track co-located with Rock Sales / SRF Salgskonferansen) anchored by a big name like Morten Brandt or Hofbauer.

3. What to offer busy experts

- **Audience & distribution** (your users + amplified reach), **co-branding and positioning** as "featured expert," **professional production** (you do the work; they show up), **content they can reuse** on their own channels, and — where appropriate and later —

compensation (honoraria for masterclasses, revenue share for co-created paid courses).
Lead with the first four; money last.

4. How to approach (outreach mechanics)

- **Warm intros first** via shared connections (Norway is small; two degrees of separation is normal). Use MFO/SRF events and LinkedIn to create warm context before any ask.
- **Provide value before asking:** genuinely engage with their content, cite their work, offer them exposure first.
- **Personalized, concise, low-pressure outreach** referencing their specific work (e.g., a Hofbauer approach should reference *Salgets helter* and its curriculum status).
- **LinkedIn is the channel:** Norway has a large, decision-maker-heavy LinkedIn base (estimates range from over 950,000 users in 2024 up to "over 1,3 millioner norske brukere" per Medianord AS); thought-leader content and genuine engagement outperform cold pitches.

5. How the association builds Leadgrid's credibility

- **Social proof / trust transfer:** "People buy from people." Featuring named, respected experts transfers their authority to Leadgrid and to the Pondus resilience module.
- **Co-branding** on academy content, **testimonials** from participating experts, and **institutional association** (MFO/SRF/university-curriculum authors) create a credibility halo with your B2B target customers.

6. Norwegian/Nordic business-culture considerations

- Small, network-driven, egalitarian, trust-based, understated ("Janteloven" — avoid boastful marketing language). Prefer substance over spin; the market is skeptical of aggressive US sales culture (note the documented Norwegian discomfort with being openly "salgsorientert"). Relationships and authenticity ("like bra i virkeligheten som på sosiale medier") matter more than polish.

7. Risks & pitfalls

- **Wrong partners / credibility dilution:** avoid low-substance "motivational" speakers; prioritize substance-backed experts (authors, academics, data-driven agencies).
- **Over-commercializing:** if the academy reads as a Leadgrid ad, experts won't associate and users won't trust it. Keep it genuinely educational.
- **Self-reported credibility:** vet claims (e.g., "toughest trainer," participant counts, "only certified expert") — favor independently verifiable signals (curriculum adoption, real research, real client references).
- **Monetization risk:** *Salg24*'s closure shows Norwegian sales-media monetization is hard; treat the academy as a trust/demand asset, not a standalone revenue line.

Recommendations

Phase 1 — Anchor (Months 1-2):

- Sign **Christian Hofbauer** as flagship editorial anchor/advisory chair (curriculum-author credibility is your strongest asset). In parallel, recruit **one active podcaster** (Ståle Lindblad or Hans Haugan) for recurring interview content.
- Formalize a light **editorial advisory board** (3-5 names spanning sales, lead gen, and academia — e.g., Hofbauer + an Inbound principal + a BI/Kristiania academic).
- *Benchmark to advance*: 2 signed anchors + 1 published piece of co-created content.

Phase 2 — Momentum (Months 3-6):

- Produce a steady cadence of **low-friction interview/podcast/tips content** repurposing experts' existing material. Cross-publish on LinkedIn.
- Secure a **community association** with MFO and/or SRF (co-hosted frokostmøte or event track).
- *Benchmark*: 8-12 published expert contributions; one community event; measurable LinkedIn engagement growth.

Phase 3 — Scale (Months 6-12):

- Launch **co-created masterclasses/webinars** and, only with proven partners, an **ambassador tier**. Consider a flagship live event or a co-located track with an established conference (Rock Sales / SRF Salgskonferansen), potentially anchored by Morten Brandt.
- *Benchmark to reconsider strategy*: if experts decline to associate, or engagement is flat, revert to pure value-first content and re-vet partner fit before adding any commercial layer.

Cross-cutting: keep every layer genuinely educational; introduce money last; prioritize independently verifiable credibility; use warm intros throughout.

Caveats

- **Follower/reach figures are largely self-reported** and change over time; only Alexander Haneng's ~14k LinkedIn following was firmly verified. Hallgeir Gustavsen's specific reach and his "only LinkedIn Certified Marketing Expert" claim are unverified self-marketing. Norway's total LinkedIn user base is cited variously (950,000+ to 1.3 million).
- "**Even Bratberg**" and the exact event names "Bergen Salgskonferanse"/"Salgsdagen" could not be verified — confirm or drop.
- Trainer credibility claims (talk counts, "toughest," participant numbers) are self-reported and unaudited.
- I was unable to independently verify details of **Leadgrid** and its **Pondus** module from the public web within the research budget (note: "Pondus" is also a well-known Norwegian

comic strip, which will affect search/SEO for the module name); the strategy is built on the brief as provided.

- Recent (2024-2025) mainstream Norwegian trade sales books are scarce; the category is dominated by older editions.